



How to change root password in Ubuntu Linux

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I am a new Ubuntu Linux server admin. How can I change root password in Ubuntu Linux server using the bash shell over ssh based session?



By default, the root user account password is locked in Ubuntu Linux for security reasons. As a result, you can not login using root user or use a command such as 'su -' to become a SuperUser.

You need to use [the passwd command to change the password for user accounts](#) on Ubuntu Linux. A typical user can only change the password for his/her account only. A SuperUser (root) can change the password for any user account. Your user account info stored in [/etc/passwd](#) and an encrypted password stored in [/etc/shadow](#) file.

How to change root password in Ubuntu

The procedure to change the root user password on Ubuntu Linux:

1. Type the following command to become root user and issue passwd:
`sudo -i`
`passwd`
2. OR set a password for root user in a single go:
`sudo passwd root`
3. Test it your root password by typing the following command:
`su -`

How to disable your root account on Ubuntu

One can disable the root account by typing the following command:

```
$ sudo passwd -dl root
```

OR

```
$ sudo passwd --delete --lock root
```

Sample session from the above commands:

```
vivek@nixcraft:~$  
vivek@nixcraft:~$ lsb_release -a  
No LSB modules are available.  
Distributor ID: Ubuntu  
Description:    Ubuntu 17.10  
Release:        17.10  
Codename:       artful  
vivek@nixcraft:~$  
vivek@nixcraft:~$ sudo passwd root  
[sudo] password for vivek:  
Enter new UNIX password:  
Retype new UNIX password:  
passwd: password updated successfully  
vivek@nixcraft:~$ su -  
Password:  
root@nixcraft:~# id  
uid=0(root) gid=0(root) groups=0(root)  
root@nixcraft:~# exit  
logout  
vivek@nixcraft:~$ sudo passwd -dl root  
passwd: password expiry information changed
```

Set a root password



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```
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vivek@nixcraft:~$
vivek@nixcraft:~$ su -
Password:
su: Authentication failure
vivek@nixcraft:~$
```

**Lock down
a root password
if needed**

Understanding passwd command option

- **-d OR --delete** : Delete a user's password (make it empty for root user). This is a quick way to disable a password for an account. It will set the named account passwordless.
- **-l OR --lock**: Lock the password of the named account such as root. This option disables a password by changing it to a value which matches no possible encrypted value (it adds a '!' at the beginning of the password)
- **root** : Lock and disble root account i.e. re-disabling your root account

A note about root password on an Ubuntu server/desktop

Enabling the root account by setting the password is not needed. Almost everything you need to do as SuperUser (root) of an Ubuntu server can be done using sudo command. For example, [restart apache server](#):

```
$ sudo systemctl restart apache2
```

You can add additional user to sudo by typing the following command:

```
$ sudo adduser {userNameHere} sudo
```

For example, add a user named tom to sudo:

```
$ sudo adduser tom sudo
```

You can in as another user say logging as tom from jerry account:

```
{jerry@nixcraft}$ sudo -l -u tom
```

When prompted enter jerry's password i.e. the password being asked for is your own, not tom's. For more info see "[How to create a new sudo user on Ubuntu Linux server](#)" and [RootSudo](#).

This entry is **5 of 13** in the **root user Tutorial** series. Keep reading the rest of the series:

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Last updated October 9, 2019 By [Abhishek Prakash](#) — [21 Comments](#)

Want to change root password in Ubuntu? Learn how to change the password for any user in Ubuntu Linux. Both terminal and GUI methods have been discussed.

When do you need to change the password in Ubuntu? Let me give you a couple of scenarios.

When you install [Ubuntu](#), you create a user and set a password for it. It could be a weak password or perhaps a bit too complicated and you want to change it.

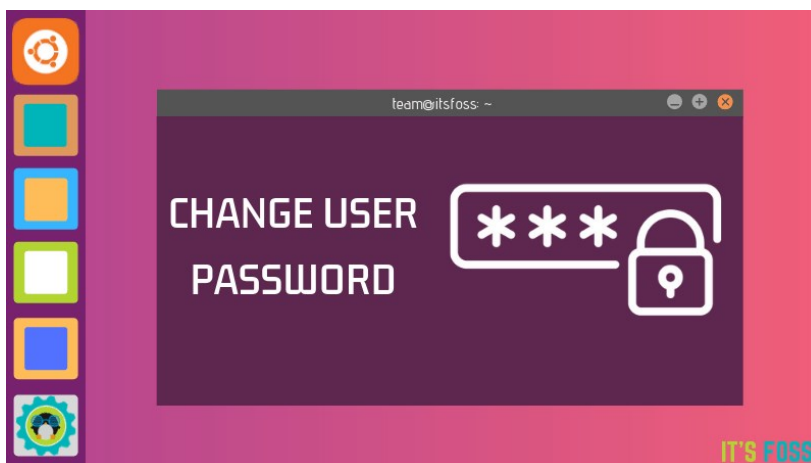
If you are a sysadmin, you may need to change the password for other users on your system.

You may have a few other reasons for doing this. Now the question comes, how to change the password for a user in Ubuntu or Linux?

In this quick tutorial, I'll show you the command line and the GUI ways of changing passwords in Ubuntu.

- [Change user password via command line](#)
- [Change root user password](#)
- [Change user password via GUI](#)

Change user password in Ubuntu [Command Line]



Changing user password in Ubuntu is dead simple. In fact, it's the same with any Linux distribution because you use the generic Linux command called `passwd` for this purpose.

If you want to change your current password, simply run this command in a terminal:

```
passwd
```

You'll be asked to enter your current password and the new password twice.

You won't see anything on the screen while typing the password. This is perfectly normal behavior for UNIX and Linux.

```
passwd

Changing password for abhishek.

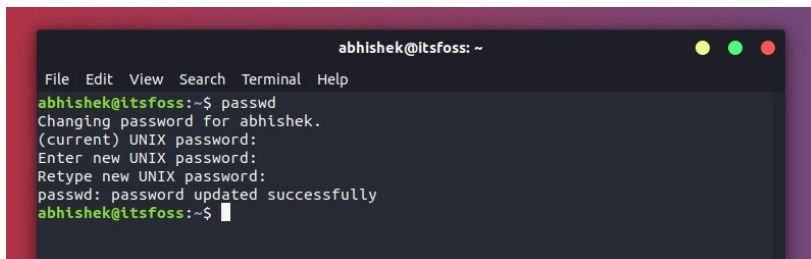
(current) UNIX password:

Enter new UNIX password:

Retype new UNIX password:

passwd: password updated successfully
```

Since this is your admin account, you just changed the sudo password in Ubuntu without even realizing it.



```
abhishek@itsfoss: ~
File Edit View Search Terminal Help
abhishek@itsfoss:~$ passwd
Changing password for abhishek.
(current) UNIX password:
Enter new UNIX password:
Retype new UNIX password:
passwd: password updated successfully
abhishek@itsfoss:~$
```

If you want to change password for some other user, you can do that as well with the `passwd` command. But in this case, you'll have to use `sudo`.

```
sudo passwd <user_name>
```

If you changed your password and forgot it later, don't worry. You can [easily reset Ubuntu password](#).

Change root password in Ubuntu

By default, the root user in Ubuntu doesn't have a password. Don't be surprised. You don't use the root user in Ubuntu all the time. Confused? Let me explain it to you quickly.

While [installing Ubuntu](#), you are forced to create a user. This user has admin access. This admin user can gain root access using the `sudo` command. But it uses its own password, not the root account's password (because there is none).

You can set or change root password using the *passwd* command. However, in most cases, you don't need it and you shouldn't be doing it.

You'll have to use `sudo` (with an account with admin privileges). If the root password has no password set up previously, it will ask you to set it up. Else, you can change it using the existing root password.

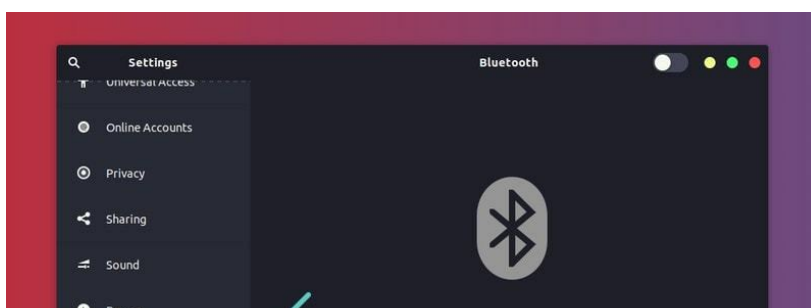
```
sudo passwd root
```

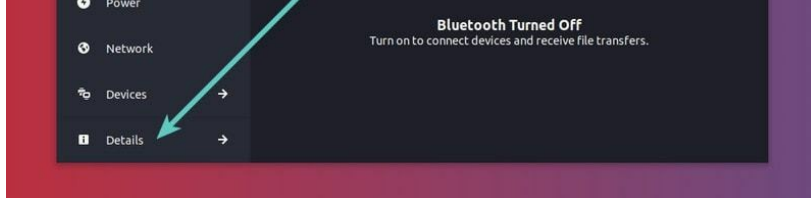
Change Ubuntu password using GUI

I have used GNOME desktop with Ubuntu 18.04 here. The steps should be more or less the same for other desktop environments and Ubuntu versions.

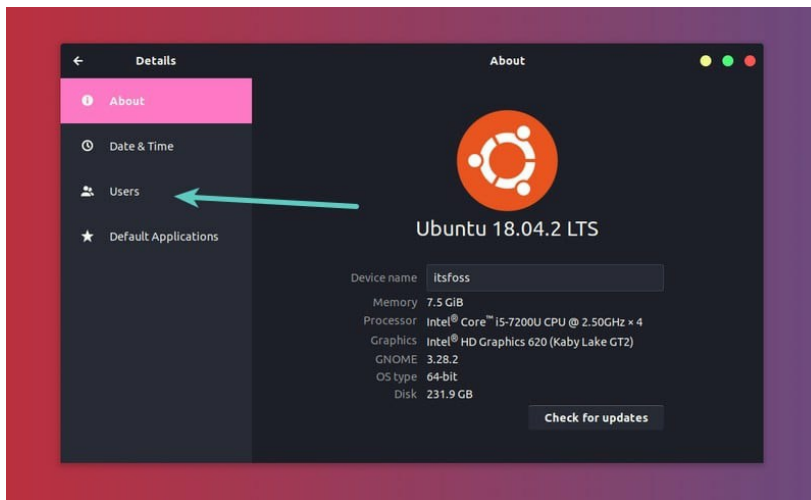
Go to Menu (press Windows/Super key) and search for Settings.

In the Settings, scroll down a bit and go to Details.

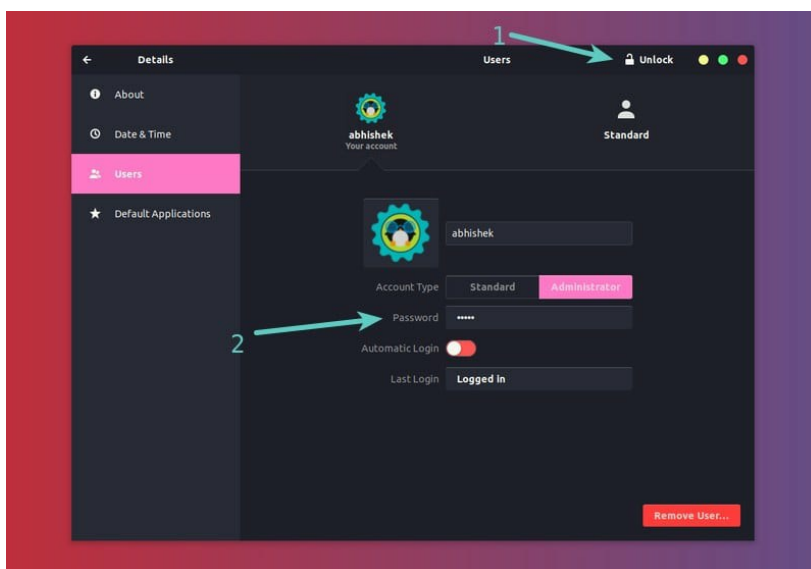




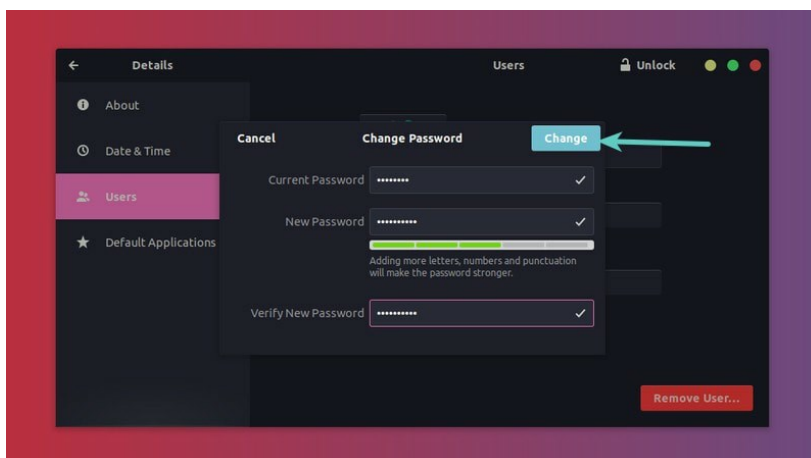
In here, click on Users to access all the available users on your system.



You can select any user you want, including your main admin account. You need to unlock the users first and then click the password field.



You'll be asked to set the password. If you are changing your own password, you'll have to enter your current password as well.



Once done, click on the Change button on the top. That's it. You have successfully changed user password in Ubuntu.